
ANI

The BJP has also consciously avoided personal attacks on chief minister Mamata Banerjee, recognising that any aggressive rhetoric could alienate the women voters and the *bhadralok* middle class. The party has fielded leader of the Opposition, Suvendu Adhikari, against her in Bhabanipur constituency (last time around, he had defeated Mamata when she took him on in his lair, Nandigram). It's also focusing on issues like women's safety, corruption and law and order. High-profile incidents like the RG Kar Medical College rape-murder case, which sparked large-scale protests in 2024, are being used to highlight the TMC regime's failures. There are reports that the party may field the RG Kar victim's mother from Panihati in North 24 Parganas.

The saffron side has also got a boost from the Election Commission, both through the SIR process—successive revisions have flagged 2-4 per cent of the electorate (700,000-1.5 million voters) for deletion, while also adding new voters—and the removal of officials perceived to be close to the TMC. Some 60 senior officials have been shunted out, including the chief secretary, DGP, home secretary and even the Kolkata police commissioner.

ASSAM

Unlike in any other BJP-ruled state, chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma, whose personal network, administrative authority and regional credibility are critical to the party, is the face of the campaign here. He is not just expected to retain Assam but to deliver a decisive mandate as well. The CM's influence extends across constituencies, communities and alliance configurations, allowing the BJP to navigate the state's complex demographic realities.

Sarma has also been able to neutralise the Muslim vote (they account for roughly 34 per cent of the population, but are concentrated in 35-40 constituencies). This has been done through a sharp campaign around alleged illegal infiltration from Bangladesh, eviction drives in districts such as Darrang, Nagaon and Barpeta, tightened land laws in tribal belts, and invoking mechanisms against doubtful voters. Sarma has also sought to draw a distinction between indigenous Assamese Muslims and 'Miya infiltrators', helping the party avoid a complete consolidation of minorities against it.

The party has also firmed up alliances. It is contesting only 89 of the total 126 seats, with the Asom Gana Parishad and the Bodoland People's Front (BPF) being allocated 26 and 11 seats respectively. The BPF's return to the NDA is significant as it has influence in 12-15 seats in the Bodoland Territorial Council belt.

Sarma's influence goes beyond categorisation, helps BJP navigate Assam's complex demographic realities

TAMIL NADU

The BJP has returned to its alliance with the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), acknowledging the limits of its post-2021 attempt to go solo. A new conciliatory state president, Nainar Nagendran, and some shrewd bargaining, has got it 27 seats, seven more than last time. That said, there is some grumbling over the choice of seats. The party is also trying to broaden its reach beyond the BJP's traditional support base of the Tamil Brahmin and Nadar communities. New state chief Nagendran is from the Thevar community (an OBC caste), which is quite influential in the southern and central districts. The state unit is also going through a political and organisational reset. Ex-state chief K. Annamalai, whose confrontational line had led to the break-up with the AIADMK earlier, has been asked to dial it down.

The numbers explain the compulsion. In the 2021 assembly poll, the BJP, in alliance with the AIADMK, managed four seats with a 2.6 per cent vote share. In the 2024 Lok Sabha election, the BJP contested largely on its own, pushed its vote share to 11 per cent, but